INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #6 · PARENTING

"I'm a failure as a parent."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Parenting is the one job where we are graded daily and never fully trained. Comparison with other parents, a child's struggles, our own childhood wounds, and criticism from relatives or church can leave us convinced that we are failing. Perfectionism tells us that any mistake is proof.

What Scripture teaches

God describes Himself as a Father who understands our limits: "As a father has compassion on his children, so the LORD has compassion on those who fear Him." He "tends His flock like a shepherd; He gathers the lambs in His arms and carries them close to His heart. He gently leads the nursing ewes." Even the best human parent needs this gentle leading. Jeremiah says of God, "His mercies never fail. They are new every morning; great is Your faithfulness!" Parenting well is not parenting perfectly. It is loving, repairing, and keeping on, and God supplies what we lack.

> *"He tends His flock like a shepherd; He gathers the lambs in His arms and carries them close to His heart. He gently leads the nursing ewes"* (Isaiah 40:11).

Also see

> "As a father has compassion on his children, so the LORD has compassion on those who fear Him" (Psalm 103:13).

> "Because of the loving devotion of the LORD we are not consumed, for His mercies never fail. They are new every morning; great is Your faithfulness!" (Lamentations 3:22–23).

> "Being confident of this, that He who began a good work in you will carry it on to completion until the day of Christ Jesus" (Philippians 1:6).

> "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me" (2 Corinthians 12:9).

Common self-statements

- Good parents do not make these mistakes.
- Everyone else is doing better than I am.
- I yelled again, so I am a terrible parent.
- My child deserves better.
- I do not know what I am doing.
- I am failing them.

Common logical errors

- Labeling: Calling myself "a failure" instead of describing a mistake.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either perfect or failing.
- Social comparison: Measuring myself against other parents' best moments.
- Discounting the positive: Overlooking the love and care I give.

Challenging questions

- What exactly have I done that I call failure, and what is the evidence on the other side?

- What would I say to a friend who was parenting as I am?
- What does my child need most, perfection or presence and repair?
- How does God treat parents who are tired and unsure?
- Where do I need to apologize, and where do I need to forgive myself?
- What is one small thing I can do well this week?

Truth summary

> I am not a perfect parent, and I do not need to be. My child needs a loving parent who repairs mistakes, not a flawless one. God leads gently those who care for little ones, and His mercies are new every morning.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Parenting
- Children
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Guilt/Shame
- Mercy

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Parenting
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

Softly and Tenderly — Kristyn Getty with Vince Gill, Ellie Holcomb and Sierra Hull
This older hymn pictures Christ's gracious invitation to return rather than hide in shame.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I'm a failure as a parent"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I'm a failure as a parent." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What do I call failure?
- ☐ What would I tell a friend?
- ☐ What does my child need?
- ☐ What do I need to repair?
- ☐ What do I do well?
- ☐ Who can support me?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Good parenting is not perfect parenting.
- ☐ God gently leads parents.
- ☐ His mercies are new every morning.
- ☐ I can apologize and repair.
- ☐ My love matters to my child.
- ☐ God will finish what He began.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Isaiah 40:11
  "He tends His flock like a shepherd; He gathers the lambs in His arms and carries them close to His heart. He gently leads the nursing ewes."
- ☐ Psalm 103:13
  "As a father has compassion on his children, so the LORD has compassion on those who fear Him."
- ☐ Lamentations 3:22–23
  "Because of the loving devotion of the LORD we are not consumed, for His mercies never fail. They are new every morning; great is Your faithfulness!"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Repair and love: Each week, write one mistake you repaired or one loving thing you did.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Isaiah 40:11 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God gently leads me as I care for my child.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Parenting" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Separate mistakes from identity. Write what happened as facts, without the word "failure."
- [ ] Apologize if needed. Tell your child a simple, sincere sorry.
- [ ] List what you do well. Write ten ways you care for your child.
- [ ] Ask for support. Talk with a trusted parent, pastor, or counselor.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I'm a failure as a parent": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A repair made
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I'm a failure as a parent.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I feel like I am failing. Lead me gently as You lead those with young. Forgive my mistakes, help me repair them, and fill in what I lack. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.